In the waning stages of World War II, the effort at governing the post-war world was led by the victorious allies, including the United States, United Kingdom, and (initially) the Soviet Union. These discussions between 1941 and 1949 produced the Bretton Woods institutions, the Atlantic Charter, the United Nations, and eventually the North Atlantic Treaty Organization. These institutions were meant to govern the post-war economy and trading order, support decolonization efforts, and manage security competition, although they quickly morphed into venues and instruments of Cold War competition. [2] Eventually, efforts such as the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) in the 1960s were advanced to manage nuclear weapon competition.

As a newly decolonized country, India was a partial beneficiary of this post-World War II order. It joined the Bretton Woods institutions and United Nations, although remained distrustful of early Cold War efforts such as NATO. It also perceived the NPT to be discriminatory and not serious about its disarmament obligations, and thus India never signed it. Later, India also did not support the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty (CTBT), which it felt would permanently have frozen nuclear 'haves' and 'have nots'. But for the most part, India voluntarily joined several multilateral institutions meant to govern global and transnational challenges. When they were not informal groupings or venues for coordination and consultation—such as the Non-Aligned Movement—they were sometimes treaty-based organizations with a governing structure, voting shares, and international obligations.

In broad terms, the numerous international institutions, agreements and arrangements that constitute modern global governance generally attempt to do three things. First, the international order helps to preserve peace between sovereign states through confidence building measures, arms control arrangements, dispute resolution mechanisms, information sharing mechanisms, and alliances and coalitions that preserve a balance of power. Indeed, matters of war and peace are what laid the foundation for international order in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. As a consequence, many disputes that had previously led to military conflict—including territorial disputes and even debt repayment—are now settled